



The space race

The late 1950s and 1960s saw a technological battle for supremacy in space between the planet's two great superpowers, the US and the Soviet Union (now Russia). The Soviets had made great strides with rocket-powered long-range missiles, which they used to launch objects into space to record a number of milestones, but the US finally caught up, forming their space agency, NASA (National Aeronautics and Space Administration), in 1958. Both nations enjoyed remarkable achievements during this period.

The race begins

Launched by the Soviet Union in 1957, Sputnik 1 was the first artificial satellite in space. It made some 1,440 orbits of Earth in three months. For its first 21 days in orbit, it sent out beeps via radio waves detectable by radio receivers on Earth.



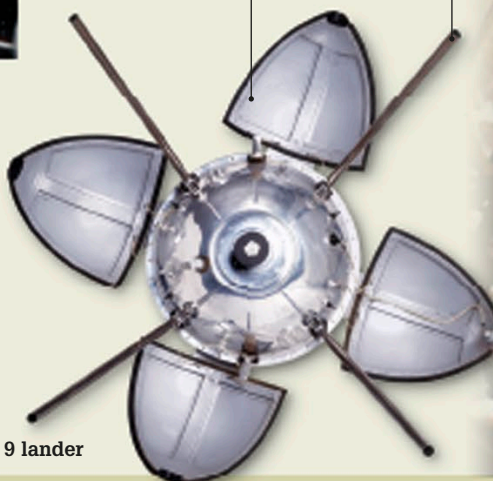
Yuri Gagarin inside Vostok 1

First travelers in space

Soviet astronaut Yuri Gagarin became the first human in space in 1961 when he orbited Earth in the tiny Vostok 1 spacecraft. His trip lasted 108 minutes and was followed by five longer Vostok missions, including Vostok 6, which made 48 orbits over 2 days, 22 hours as it carried the first woman in space—Valentina Tereshkova.

Hinged panels, which protected the craft during the descent to the Moon, unfolded like petals after landing.

Television antenna transmitted pictures to Earth.



Luna 9 lander

Space probes

Space probes are unmanned machines sent to explore space. The Soviet spacecraft Luna 3 photographed the dark side of the Moon in 1959. Mariner 2, an American space probe, was the first to visit another planet when it reached Venus three years later. In 1966, Luna 9 made the first soft landing on the Moon.

Key events

1958

In response to the Soviet Sputnik 1, the US launched its first space satellite, Explorer 1, which sent back signals to Earth for 105 days.

1962

Astronaut John Glenn, inside a Mercury spacecraft, became the first American to orbit Earth, spending 4 hours, 35 minutes in space.



1965

Soviet astronaut Alexey Leonov left his Voskhod 2 spacecraft to perform the first ever spacewalk. He was tethered to the craft and the walk lasted 12 minutes.